

Primary Source Reading 1: The Sun and the Divided Line

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Republic, Book VI, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 18a: The Divided Line

Before you read: Socrates has been trying to say what the Form of the Good is, and finds it easier to describe by comparison than to define directly. As you read, notice the analogy he builds between the sun and the Good — and then follow him as he turns that analogy into a precise, four-part map of reality and knowledge.

The Good Is Like the Sun

The soul is like the eye: when resting upon that on which truth and being shine, the soul perceives and understands, and is radiant with intelligence; but when turned towards the twilight of becoming and perishing, then she has opinion only, and goes blinking about, and is first of one opinion and then of another, and seems to have no intelligence.

Now, that which imparts truth to the known and the power of knowing to the knower is what I would have you term the idea of good, and this you will deem to be the cause of science, and of truth in so far as the latter becomes the subject of knowledge; beautiful too, as are both truth and knowledge, you will be right in esteeming this other nature as more beautiful than either; and, as in the previous instance, light and sight may be truly said to be like the sun, and yet not to be the sun, so in this other sphere, science and truth may be deemed to be like the good, but not the good; the good has a place of honour yet higher.

The Line Divided

Now take a line which has been cut into two unequal parts, and divide each of them again in the same proportion, and suppose the two main divisions to answer, one to the visible and the other to the intelligible, and then compare the subdivisions in respect of their clearness and want of clearness, and you will find that the first section in the sphere of the visible consists of images. And by images I mean, in the first place, shadows, and in the second place, reflections in water and in solid, smooth and polished bodies and the like.

Imagine, now, the other section, of which this is only the resemblance, to include the animals which we see, and everything that grows or is made.

Would you not admit that both the sections of this division have different degrees of truth, and that the copy is to the original as the sphere of opinion is to the sphere of knowledge?

The Two Subdivisions of the Intelligible

There are two subdivisions, in the lower of which the soul uses the figures given by the former division as images; the enquiry can only be hypothetical, and instead of going upwards to a principle descends to the other end; in the higher of the two, the soul passes out of hypotheses, and goes up to a principle which is above hypotheses, making no use of images as in the former case, but proceeding only in and through the ideas themselves.

You are aware that students of geometry, arithmetic, and the kindred sciences assume the odd and the even and the figures and three kinds of angles and the like in their several branches of science; these are their hypotheses, which they and every body are supposed to know, and therefore they do not deign to give any account of them.

After you read: Notice that mathematics, in Plato's picture, is a real advance over ordinary opinion — it grasps universal truths, not just particular appearances — but it is still not the top of the line, because it reasons *from* assumptions it never examines. Only the highest level, Plato says, goes all the way up to a principle that needs no further assumption behind it. As you read the lesson, try mapping a few of your own school subjects onto these four levels, and notice how much of ordinary education never leaves Level 3.